NewsBank inc.

# California strengthens penalties for post-disaster looting

February 13, 2026 | Simi Valley Acorn (CA)
Author: wpeditor | Section: News | 297 Words
OpenURL Link

Wildfires that sweep through swaths of Southern California neighborhoods bring destruction, fear and loss. Home and business owners have enough on their plate; they shouldn't also have to worry about theft.

That's the premise of a new state law penned in response to widespread looting and impersonation crimes following last year's deadly wildfires in Los Angeles. Ventura County residents were hit with similar concerns in the 2018 Woolsey fire and, more recently, Camarillo's 2024 Mountain fire.

A set of bills signed into law by Gov. Gavin Newsom in October strengthens penalties for looting during declared emergencies, extends protections into the recovery and rebuilding phase following disasters and reinforces penalties for individuals who impersonate firefighters, law enforcement officers or other officials during emergencies. This set of public safety laws was strongly supported by Ventura County District Attorney Erik Nasarenko.

"Ventura County is no stranger to disaster, and our residents know firsthand how devastating these events can be," said Nasarenko. "When families are evacuating from a dangerous fire and first responders are risking their lives, we can't have criminals exploiting the chaos and devastation. These new laws will allow us to crack down on looters and criminal impersonators."

District 46 Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, who represents the area neighboring Simi Valley to the east as well as Woodland Hills and Encino and wrote Assembly Bill 468, said he is proud to join efforts with first responders to keep them and the community safe.

"Individuals who put our firefighters at risk and prey on communities when they are at their most vulnerable must be held accountable," he said.

"Looters, particularly those who impersonate emergency personnel, create chaos and confusion, endanger residents and first responders, and victimize communities that already have suffered unimaginable harm."

The post California strengthens penalties for post-disaster looting first appeared on Simi Valley Acorn.

Copyright (c) 2026, Simi Valley Acorn (CA), All rights reserved

- **Citation (apa Style)**
wpeditor. (2026, February 13). California strengthens penalties for post-disaster looting.*Simi Valley Acorn (CA).* Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A63E69FBB25A1D0.